

Lesson 5: The Strength of Female Leadership

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OK, we've discussed biases and obstacles. Now let's talk strengths!

The truth is, if you're not utilizing the unique strengths of women on your leadership team, you're missing out! While it's important to avoid biases about either sex, this doesn't mean ignoring some of the unique characteristics and perceptions that women bring to the leadership roundtable.

How many times have you stepped into a man's office, and it was apparent that no woman had ever set foot there. At least, no woman had had a say in the decorating! By contrast, how many times have you visited a woman's office, and it was obvious no man visited it frequently – pastels, flowers, you name it. This is what your leadership team looks like, metaphorically speaking, when it's all one-sided. You need *both* genders contributing to the overall landscape of your leadership team to bring balance.

While every woman is different, women are traditionally known for:

- Emotional intelligence
- Empathy
- Collaboration
- Communication
- Attention to detail
- Strategic thinking
- Risk aversion
- Resilience and adaptability, just to name a few.

How many times have you had a one-sided hiring committee who picked a job candidate and then discovered there were major red flags when they started the job that were missed? How many times have you had a team of "idea people" in a room and made a decision without thoroughly assessing the details? Have you ever encountered a brilliant manager who was a visionary thinker, but couldn't communicate well?

Again, leadership teams need balance – both males *and* females – to bring an equilibrium to corporate leadership and decision-making. Each gender has its own strengths and weaknesses.

Oprah Winfrey, Ruth Bader Ginsberg, Queen Elizabeth II, Sheryl Sandberg, Mary Kay Ash, Melinda Gates – you may be familiar with these names, but there are many more.

How about, Mary Barra, CEO of General Motors and the first woman to lead a major global automaker. Marillyn Hewson, the former CEO of Lockheed Martin, known for her leadership in aerospace and defense. Beth Ford, CEO of Land O'Lakes, or Ursula Burns the former CEO of Xerox Corporation, and the first African American woman to lead a Fortune 500 company, just to name a few!

The reality is women bring a certain depth, strength, and strategic advantage to every organization.

Let's find out more.